

Constraint Collapse

Canonical Concept Paper

A. Jacobs | Reality Drift Framework

Canonical Definition

Constraint Collapse is a systemic condition in which feedback, consequence, and correction remain present in symbolic systems but lose their ability to enforce change. Systems continue to operate and update representations, yet no longer possess reliable mechanisms for invalidating error or stopping misaligned processes.

As this condition develops, representations remain fluent and coherent while their binding to external reality weakens. Correction becomes optional, and continuation becomes the default mode of operation. The system does not fail in the traditional sense. It persists while losing the ability to correct itself.

What Makes It Distinct

Constraint Collapse differs from traditional failure modes like error, inefficiency, or misaligned incentives. Most frameworks assume failure occurs when systems produce incorrect outputs, feedback loops break down, or incentives distort behavior. Constraint Collapse points to something deeper.

Feedback can continue to flow, errors can still be detected, and systems can remain responsive, yet that feedback no longer forces correction. The system continues to operate without being accountable to reality. This is not the absence of feedback, but the loss of its binding force.

Unlike Goodhart's Law or standard optimization failures, which describe the distortion of metrics, Constraint Collapse describes a condition in which a system loses the ability to invalidate itself, even when misalignment is clearly visible.

Mechanism

Constraint Collapse emerges from the interaction of core dynamics within scaled symbolic systems:

- **Delayed or externalized consequence** weakens the immediacy of feedback
- **Compression outpaces validation**, allowing models to substitute for reality
- **Procedural momentum** sustains continuity, even as alignment degrades
- **Representations remain legible**, enabling coordination despite declining accuracy

As these dynamics compound, feedback becomes slower and more abstract, correction becomes costly, and stopping conditions lose authority. Systems continue to optimize internal representations,

while feedback circulates without enforcing change. At this point, constraint no longer binds action to consequence. It becomes informational rather than corrective.

How It Shows Up

- Constraint Collapse produces a recognizable pattern across domains:
- Systems continue functioning despite persistent, known issues
- Postmortems identify problems without producing meaningful change
- Metrics improve while outcomes degrade
- Errors accumulate without triggering decisive correction
- Organizations remain stable while losing orientation

Nothing appears broken, yet correction becomes rare, stopping becomes difficult, and misalignment persists without escalation. Feedback remains present, but it no longer forces change. What remains is operational continuity without correction.

Cross-Domain Effects

Constraint Collapse emerges wherever symbolic systems scale.

AI / Technology: Models generate coherent outputs while drifting from user intent or real-world grounding. Feedback exists, but often refines outputs rather than correcting underlying errors.

Work / Organizations: Processes continue despite known inefficiencies. Accountability mechanisms persist symbolically but fail to enforce meaningful change.

Institutions: Policies and metrics update continuously, yet fail to re-anchor systems to real-world outcomes.

Human Cognition: Individuals remain responsive and productive, yet experience disorientation as effort no longer reliably produces clarity or correction.

Theoretical Context

Constraint Collapse develops as Reality Drift persists under optimization pressure. A system can continue refining its internal measures while the representations guiding it lose contact with underlying conditions. As this happens, feedback may still identify errors without retaining the force to change decisions or stop a process.

Constraint Collapse names that loss of corrective force. It also deepens Reality Drift. Once feedback no longer binds the system to consequences, misaligned representations can continue circulating and governing action. Drift weakens correction, and weakened correction allows drift to persist.

Practical Implications

Because Constraint Collapse is structural, surface-level fixes often fail. Common responses like adding more metrics, increasing monitoring, or refining reporting systems tend to intensify the condition by adding layers of representation rather than restoring constraint.

What's needed instead is a return to binding mechanisms. That means shortening the feedback loops between action and consequence, reintroducing meaningful stopping conditions, and reducing reliance on purely symbolic indicators. It also involves increasing the cost of persistent misalignment and prioritizing correction over continuity.

The goal is not more information. It is restoring the ability to act on it.

In One Sentence

Constraint Collapse is the condition in which feedback, consequence, and correction remain present but lose their binding force, allowing misalignment to persist without enforcing change.